NOVEMBER 4 – 12, 2026 · FIRST TRIP

Nine days in *Japan.*

Tokyo, one night in the Niigata mountains, one night at Lake Kawaguchiko. Times are Japan Standard Time. Add 10 minutes inside Shinjuku, Tokyo, and Shibuya stations.

Narita — Wed 4
Ueno — 3 nights
Niigata — Sat 7
Akihabara — Sun 8
Fuji — Mon 9
Shinjuku — 2 nights
Narita — Thu 12

WED 4 · DAY 1
Land in Ueno
Skyliner, 41 min. Miura Misaki sushi.

THU 5 · DAY 2
Asakusa, then Sky
Street sunset 16:42. Roof at 18:20.

FRI 6 · DAY 3
Old Tokyo houses
Museum, Nakano, Harajuku, monja.

SAT 7 · DAY 4
Koi, then onsen
Backpack only. Izumiya kaiseki.

SUN 8 · DAY 5
Owls at 14:00
Toki around 10:19. Then Akihabara.

MON 9 · DAY 6
Lake Kawaguchiko
Fuji Excursion 09:30. Hōtō lunch.

TUE 10 · DAY 7
Red pagoda
398 steps. Back on the 14:08.

WED 11 · DAY 8
Skytree & Kirby
Solamachi shops. Tempura at 19:00.

THU 12 · DAY 9
Fly at 17:30
N'EX by 13:45. Be at Narita 14:30.

Lock these in.

TICKETS & TABLES

BOOKED · THURSDAY NOV 5

Shibuya Sky
enter 18:20

Night view, not sunset. Sunset is 16:42, from the street. Stay until you leave for dinner at 19:40. No re-entry. No suitcase.

BOOKED · SUNDAY NOV 8

Akiba Fukurou
session 14:00

Be outside at 13:40. 67 Kanda Neribeicho, 3 minutes from JR Akihabara Central Gate. About one hour. They do not serve a meal.

☐ THU 5 · 20:00

Ushigoro Kan

Yakiniku, Ebisu, 2 minutes from the station. Shoes off. About ¥10,000–15,000. Tabelog or 050-5872-3765. Upgrade if a table appears: Ebisu Yoroniku.

☐ FRI 6 · 19:30

Iroha Honten

Monjayaki in Tsukishima, since 1955. Order sakura-ebi monja. About ¥4,000–6,000. 050-5594-0795. Backup: Monja Okame.

☐ WED 11 · 19:00

Tsunahachi

Edomae tempura, Shinjuku, since 1924. Short walk from MIMARU Shinjuku West. Tendon or the set. About ¥4,000–8,000.

Sunday train: book the 10:19 Toki, Nagaoka → Ueno.

About 1 hour 25–35 minutes, reserved seat near ¥9,320. Taxi from the ryokan at 9:15. The 10:45 still works. An 11:55 gets you to Ueno around 13:20 and misses a calm 14:00 owl check-in. There is no 11:00 train that arrives at 12:35.

NOV 4–7

MIMARU Ueno North
7-14-4 Ueno · suitcases stay

NOV 7

Izumiya, Yomogihira
Backpack only. Forward the big bags in the morning.

NOV 8

MIMARU Inaricho
Bags should already be in the room.

NOV 9

Maruei, Kawaguchiko
Take the suitcases. Taxi from the station.

NOV 10–12

MIMARU Shinjuku West
Last two nights. Unpack fully.

ALSO BOOK

Kirby Café Nov 11
Fuji Excursion 9:30 out, 14:08 back. N'EX home.

01
WED

Land, walk, sushi.

Narita → Keisei-Ueno → Ameyoko. Suitcases come with you.

SLEEP
MIMARU Tokyo
Ueno North

15:40	**Land at Narita** Economy Plus, so you are off the plane early. Check the terminal on the boarding pass: 1, 2, or 3.
15:40–16:50	**Immigration, bags, customs** Plan on 60–90 minutes the first time. Longer if the hall is full.
16:50–17:15	**Phone, Suica, Skyliner seat** Turn on the eSIM or pick up pocket Wi-Fi. Charge a Suica with ¥5,000–10,000. Screenshot the Skyliner car and seat.
17:20–18:05	**Skyliner to Keisei-Ueno · 41 min** Not an hour. Trains every 20–40 minutes. Suitcases go in the racks at the end of the car. About ¥2,470.
18:05–18:25	**Walk to the hotel** 8–12 minutes from Keisei-Ueno toward the Iriya side. Follow the map pin, not a random “Ueno” sign.
18:25–19:00	**Check in and say three things** Saturday night is a backpack. Please forward the big suitcases to MIMARU Ueno Inaricho on Saturday morning. Ask what time they need them.
19:00	**Convenience-store dinner backup** Egg-salad sandwich, onigiri, milk bread. Fried chicken is Lawson Karaage-kun or FamilyMart Famichiki. 7-Eleven does not sell Famichiki.
19:45–21:15	**Sushirun 1 · Miura Misaki-kō** 8–12 minute walk into Ameyoko. Negitoro and salmon belly. If the line is awful, Toriton nearby. Then sleep. Jet lag wins.

ATM Seven Bank inside 7-Eleven

Keep out passport for the front desk

Carry-on both battery packs, never in the checked bag

02
THU

Street sunset, roof at night.

Asakusa in the morning. Shibuya Sky is 18:20, after the sun is gone.

SLEEP
MIMARU Tokyo
Ueno North

09:20	**Ginza Line to Asakusa · 5–7 min** ¥180. Exit toward Kaminarimon. Red lantern, then Nakamise-dōri. Eat in this order: warm ningyō-yaki, strawberry daifuku, Asakusa Menchi, Kagetsudō melon pan. Then Sensō-ji and the pagoda.
12:35	**Same line straight to Shibuya** About 35 minutes on the train, 45–50 door to door. ¥250.
13:20–15:00	**Shibuya Parco, 6th floor** Nintendo Tokyo and Pokémon Center Shibuya. This is not the Skytree store. If they are handing out numbered tickets, take one or come back later.
15:10–16:10	**Sushirun 2 · Uobei, Dōgenzaka** 8–12 minutes from Parco. English screen, plates on the little tracks. This is the sushi. Dinner is beef.
16:15–17:45	**Sunset from the street. Sun sets 16:42.** Miyashita Park roof by 16:30. Then the scramble itself. Then MEGA Don Quijote on Center-gai for KitKats and small things.
18:20–19:40	**Shibuya Sky · ticketed entry** Be at the 14F gate by 17:50. Lit crossing, Skytree to the east. You can stay until about 22:30, but leave at 19:40. One exit. If wind closes the roof, the indoor gallery on 46 still opens.
20:00–22:00	**Ushigoro Kan, Ebisu** One Yamanote stop, 2 minutes. Shoes off, sunken seats, 2-hour table. Back to Ueno about 35 minutes.

TICKET
Shibuya Sky 18:20 is a night view. A day backpack is fine. A suitcase is not. Locker a stuffed pack at Shibuya Station first.

IF THE SHOPS ARE SLAMMED
Pokémon Center Skytree Town on Wednesday has different stock. Do not burn the sunset hour in a line.

03
FRI

Houses, then Harajuku.

West Tokyo in the morning. The owl café is not today.

SLEEP
MIMARU Tokyo
Ueno North

08:30 — **Leave after breakfast**
Yamanote to Shinjuku (~25 min), Chūō Rapid to Musashi-Koganei (~25 min). North exit, Seibu bus platform 2 or 3. Off at Koganei-kōen Nishi-guchi, 5-minute walk. Door to door 75–85 minutes.

09:45–14:15 — **Edo-Tokyo Open Air Architectural Museum**
Inside the park. November hours 9:30–16:30, last entry 16:00, ¥400. Go into the houses. Find Kodakara-yu, the old bath that fed the look of the one in Spirited Away. Lunch at the museum café around 13:00.

14:50–16:20 — **Nakano Broadway**
Bus back, then the Chūō line, about 20 minutes. Mandarake and vintage figures. A different pile from Akihabara, which is Sunday.

16:50–18:20 — **Harajuku, small bites only**
Chūō to Shinjuku, Yamanote to Harajuku, about 25 minutes total. One crêpe or takoyaki on Takeshita-dōri, then Cat Street. Dinner is a full meal.

19:30–21:15 — **Iroha Honten, Tsukishima**
Yamanote to Yūrakuchō, then the subway, 35–40 minutes. Leave Harajuku at 18:20. Sakura-ebi monja. Staff cook it with you. Back to Ueno about 40 minutes. Pack the Niigata backpack tonight.

IF YOU ALREADY HOLD GHIBLI TICKETS
Do the museum in Mitaka this morning and skip the open-air park. Both want half a day. Nakano and Harajuku still fit after.

IF THE BUILDINGS GRAB YOU
Stay until 15:30 and drop Nakano, not Harajuku. Rain: the rooms are indoors, the paths are not. Nakano Broadway is the indoor swap.

04
SAT

Koi ponds, then the mountain bath.

The 40L is your only bag. Ojiya and the ryokan are different taxi rides from Nagaoka.

SLEEP
Yomogihira
Onsen Izumiya

07:00	**Backpack only** One spare outfit, sleep shirt, socks, mini toiletries, both batteries, charger, warm layer, cash, a plastic bag. Yukata and towels are at the inn. No second pair of shoes.
07:30	**Hand the suitcases to MIMARU** Forward them to MIMARU Tokyo Ueno Inaricho for Sunday. Get a receipt. They may arrive late morning, not at 8:00.
08:30	**Toki, Tokyo Station → Nagaoka** Ueno to Tokyo is 8–9 minutes. Ride about 1 hour 35–50. Reserved seat, roughly ¥9,000–11,000. Watch for the mountains after the long tunnel.
10:30–13:00	**Nishikigoi no Sato, Ojiya** Taxi 35–45 minutes is the calm way. Train to Ojiya is 20 minutes, then a bus. Wooden bridges, collector koi, feed them, then leave. This is the birthplace of colored koi.
13:00	**Sushirun 4 · lunch in Ojiya** A local counter near the station, Niigata rice under the fish. Sushimasa if it is open. Then a taxi to Izumiya, 40–55 minutes. Or return to Nagaoka East for the inn's shuttle, which runs about 13:30–17:00 and must be reserved.
15:00	**Check in. Book tomorrow's taxi.** You need to be at Nagaoka Station by 9:50 on Sunday. Ask them to have a taxi at 9:15. Then the alkaline outdoor bath. Shower first. No swimsuit.
19:00	**Kaiseki in the room** Murakami wagyu on the hot stone, if that is your menu. Futons appear while you eat. Sleep early.

Cash rural taxis still want it

App GO taxi, plus the inn's phone number

Tattoos ask before the public bath

05
SUN

Owls at two o’clock.

The early train is the whole trick. Akihabara happens after, not before.

SLEEP
MIMARU Tokyo
Ueno Inaricho

> Leave Izumiya at 9:15. Toki around 10:19. Ueno around 11:45.
> Backup train is about 10:45, and then lunch becomes a station bento. Do not take the train near 11:55.

07:45–08:45	**Breakfast at the inn** Still sit down for it. Checkout by 9:15 with the backpack only.
09:15–09:45	**Taxi to Nagaoka, east side** 25–30 minutes. Be at the Shinkansen gate with time to spare.
10:19	**Toki to Ueno · about 1h30** Reserved ordinary around ¥9,320. Get off at Ueno, not Tokyo.
11:50–13:15	**Drop the bag. Eat lunch.** MIMARU Inaricho is a 5–8 minute walk, or 3 minutes from Inaricho station. If the room is not ready, the desk holds the backpack. Do not unpack. Lunch in Ueno or Ameyoko. You will not be fed with the owls.
13:15	**One stop to Akihabara** Hibiya Line, about 3 minutes. Or walk 15.
13:40–14:50	**Akiba Fukurou · session 14:00** From the Central Gate, turn left. Yodobashi-Akiba is on your right. White building next to the vet. Slippers on. Staff handle the birds. About 50–60 minutes.
14:50–17:30	**Akihabara, unhurried** Super Potato, one GiGO crane floor, then Radio Kaikan or Mandarake. Yodobashi if you need a cable or a memory card.
18:15	**Sushirun 3 · Miura Misaki-kō again** JR back to Ueno in 3–6 minutes. Order what you skipped on Wednesday. If you would rather not repeat the shop, eat Ganso Zushi at Manseibashi at 17:30 and skip the hop. Hotel is 5–10 minutes after. Open the forwarded suitcases and lay out Fuji clothes.

06
MON

Up to the lake.

Suitcases ride the Fuji Excursion. The hotel shuttle is too late for your arrival.

SLEEP
Maruei
Kawaguchiko

08:00	**Inaricho → Shinjuku with the big bags** Yamanote, 25–30 minutes, plus Shinjuku's walking. Follow signs for Limited Express Fuji Excursion, 富士回遊.
09:30–11:28	**Fuji Excursion to Kawaguchiko** About 1 hour 58 minutes. All seats reserved, about ¥4,200. Luggage space at the end of the car. Stops include Shimoyoshida, which you will use tomorrow.
11:30	**Taxi to Maruei · 8–10 min** The free shuttle usually starts at 14:00. Do not wait for it. Drop the bags even if the room is not ready.
12:00–13:45	**Hōtō Fudō** The white cloud-shaped building. Flat noodles, miso, pumpkin, mountain vegetables. Confirm the Kawaguchiko branch on the map. There is more than one.
14:00	**Lake edge, if the mountain is out** November is a good month. Afternoons still cloud over. Morning light tomorrow is the better bet.
15:00	**Check in** Lake-view room: beds plus tatami. Fill the private indoor bath. Rooftop deck for dusk. Sunset near the lake is about 16:40.
18:30	**Dinner in the hotel** Multi-course, on site. Stay in. Ask if they can hold bags in the morning while you climb to the pagoda.

Dawn look at Fuji before breakfast tomorrow

Train home target the 14:08, not a vague afternoon

07
TUE

The red pagoda, then Ginza.

Lock the suitcases. Climb light. Be on the 14:08 back to Shinjuku.

SLEEP
MIMARU Tokyo
Shinjuku West

07:30	**Breakfast and a Fuji check** Clearest light is early. Then checkout.
08:30–09:15	**Taxi to Kawaguchiko Station** 8–10 minutes. Big lockers fill on clear days. Staffed storage is the backup.
09:30–11:30	**Chūreitō Pagoda** Local train to Shimoyoshida, 5–10 minutes. Walk 10–15 minutes, then 398 stone steps. Red five stories, Fuji behind them if the sky allows. Water in the small bag only.
11:30–13:30	**Back, a snack, reclaim the bags** Station ramen or a convenience store. You want the luggage in hand before 13:30.
14:08–16:08	**Fuji Excursion to Shinjuku** About 2 hours. Backup is 14:58, arriving about 16:59. The 16:48 and 17:41 erase Ginza.
16:15	**MIMARU Shinjuku West** 10–15 minutes from the station with luggage. Unpack for two nights.
17:00–18:30	**Ginza** 20–30 minutes from Shinjuku. Sanrio World, then A Happy Pancake for the soufflé stack. Lines happen.
19:00–20:30	**Sushirun 5 · Sushi Zanmai, Tsukiji** About 15 minutes on foot from Ginza. Otoro and chūtoro. If the line is past 40 minutes, eat at a counter on the same block. Bird Land, the Ginza yakitori, only if you already hold a 19:30 table — then skip Zanmai.

08
WED

Tower, Kirby, tempura.

Bags stay in Shinjuku. Start the backpack almost empty.

SLEEP
MIMARU Tokyo
Shinjuku West

09:15–10:00	**Shinjuku → Tokyo Skytree** 35–50 minutes door to door. Follow Solamachi / Skytree Town signs, not a random tower exit.
10:00–11:30	**Tembo Deck, and Galleria if you bought it** Fast elevators, glass floor, the bay. A timed ticket skips the worst line. Door tickets still exist.
12:00–14:00	**Kirby Café, Solamachi 4F** Your timed slot. Star pizza, the burger in the ceramic block, dessert. They turn the table. If you have no reservation: eat elsewhere in the building and still do the shop next door.
14:00–17:00	**The 4th-floor loop** Kirby Café Store, then Pokémon Center Skytree Town, then Donguri Republic for Ghibli. Different goods from Shibuya. Plush goes in the tote. Wrap the ceramic or carry it.
17:40	**Leave for Shinjuku** 35–50 minutes. A claw machine is allowed only if it cannot make you late.
19:00–20:45	**Tsunahachi Sohonten** Tempura since 1924, a short walk from the station and the hotel. Order the tendon or the set. Then pack the suitcases. Tomorrow starts with a clock.

Reservation Kirby Café, timed

Reservation Tsunahachi, 19:00

Fragile Kirby ceramic rides in the jacket or in your hand

09
THU

Last sushi, then the airport.

Flight at 17:30 from Narita. Be in the terminal at 14:30.

DEPART
Narita
17:30

THE MATH
N'EX from Tokyo Station is 53–60 minutes. Be on that train by 13:45. Character Street is a short lap, not a second shopping day.

IF THE MORNING SLIPS
Skip Character Street first. Be on a train toward Narita by 14:00 only if you accept a bad afternoon. Three hours at the airport is the rule.

09:30–10:30	**Pack and check out of Shinjuku West** Both batteries, meds, and one change of clothes ride in the backpack. Heavy plush goes in the checked suitcases. Fragile figures stay with you.
10:30–11:15	**Shinjuku → Tokyo Station** 30–45 minutes with luggage. Do not budget the empty-handed time.
11:15–11:45	**Lockers or the baggage desk** Big cases go in. Passport, cards, and the daypack stay out. Coin lockers fill. Have the staffed counter as plan B.
11:45–13:00	**Sushirun 6 · Nemuro Hanamaru** KITTE Marunouchi, 5th floor, across from the Marunouchi south side. Not the station basement. Hokkaido fish. No reservations. Sit down early and be standing up at 13:00.
13:00–13:25	**Tokyo Character Street** First Avenue, one floor down. One focused lap. Buy only what still fits.
13:25–13:40	**Bags, then the N'EX gate** Reserved seats. Confirm Terminal 1 or Terminal 2·3 on the ticket.
13:45–14:45	**Narita Express · 53–60 min** Then check-in, security, and the gate. Be at the gate 30 minutes before 17:30.

Cleaner option Forward suitcases hotel → Narita the day before, if the cutoff allows

From Shinjuku direct N'EX is 80–90 min, so it leaves even earlier

What the 40L holds.

LEAVE THE LAPTOP AT HOME

Every city day, one-third full. Passport in an inner zip. One 10,000 mAh pack and a short cable. Jacket, compact umbrella, empty bottle, tissues, plasters, meds. A flat foldable tote for plush, so the pack stays for flat and fragile things. The second battery stays charging in the room, except on the travel days: Nov 4, 7, 8, 9, 10, and 12. Batteries never go in a checked suitcase.

Wed 4 · carry-on

Passport, meds, both batteries, cables, earbuds, one change of clothes, toothbrush, jacket, empty bottle, eye mask.

Thu 5 · light

Daily kit and a jacket for the roof. Eat the street food. Do not bag it.

Fri 6 · walking

Daily kit, tote, shoes you can wear for hours. The museum paths add up.

Sat–Sun morning · only bag

Outfit on your body, one spare, sleep shirt, underwear, socks, mini toiletries, both batteries, charger, warm layer, taxi cash.

Sun afternoon · shopping

Dump the ryokan clothes at Inaricho first. Games in the pack, plush in the tote.

Mon 9 · personal item

Daily kit, jacket, water, both batteries. Clothes stay in the suitcase on the train.

Tue 10 · stairs, then shops

Water, jacket, phone, battery, passport for the 398 steps. Sanrio bags come after the lockers.

Wed 11 · almost empty

Daily kit, tote, a soft pouch. The Kirby ceramic does not go under a stack of plush.

Thu 12 · carry-on again

Passport, meds, both batteries, cables, jacket, one outfit, headphones, fragile souvenirs. Heavy plush is checked.

HOP	TIME	
Narita → Ueno, Skyliner	41 min	Reserved
Ueno → Asakusa, Ginza Line	5–7 min	¥180
Asakusa → Shibuya, Ginza Line	35 min ride	~50 door to door
Ueno → museum	75–85 min	Bus at the end
Tokyo → Nagaoka	1h35–1h50	Sat morning
Nagaoka → Ueno	1h25–1h35	Sun ~10:19
Shinjuku → Kawaguchiko	~1h58	Mon 09:30
Kawaguchiko → Shinjuku	~2h	Tue 14:08
Tokyo → Narita, N'EX	53–60 min	Thu 13:45